

6.1 Mobile Entertainment: Challenges and Possibilities

Karenza Moore and Jason Rutter of the University Of Manchester, England, provide some insights into this subject.

The mobile phone can be thought of as a key cultural artefact in modern social life. Mobile phones have become mundane, everyday devices that have been quickly integrated into routine practices. However, despite their perceived mundane and 'pedestrian' nature, technological development means that they also represent a significant face of cutting-edge digital entertainment. Mobile entertainment, it is hoped, will drive the sales of new handsets and increase service provider revenues as people use the data networks to send photographs, play games, find a nearby restaurant or get cinema listings with their phones. Here we concentrate on the consumer side of the mobile entertainment equation.

Despite considerable enthusiasm within the mobile sector with regards mobile entertainment (often described as the 'saviour' of the industry), it is not yet entirely clear whether mobile entertainment will become as indispensable for consumers as mobile communication has become.

Mobile Entertainment: European Facts and Figures

Penetration:

In 2003, 70 per cent of Europeans used a mobile phone. Mobile penetration in Europe grew from 53 per cent of the population in 2000 to 66 per cent in 2002.

Saturation:

Some analysts maintain that the saturation point has been reached in most Western nations. Mobile subscriber levels are predicted to stagnate at around the 300 million mark in Europe for the foreseeable future.